



THE LEFT FRONT is now turning into a house divided after Nandigram with rebel forces is waiting for the opportune moment to cut Buddhadeb to size



SIPRA DAS

30 years now. The economic transition has been too fast for comfort. The infiltration of the lumpens in the CPI(M) is what started the degeneration. A large section of the underprivileged are moving away from the mainstream during this huge transition period. It's difficult to keep pace. The leaders should understand this and not neglect the seething anger within and at the lowest levels. They must introspect." Adds actor Aparna Sen, "Buddhadeb was interested in resurgence of industry in Bengal and we support him on this. But the manner in which the Left has gone about it all makes everyone think that he should have had more foresight and taken the mantle of leadership in a more responsible manner. Thirty years of undisputed rule has made them incredibly arrogant. A sympathetic gesture, or a word of apology on Nandigram from the Left would have appeased people. Instead, they kept defending criminals. The Left has lost the will to be humble."

At the Central level, apart from the prime ministerial admonitions, the political pres-

sure is also starting to build. Opposition leader L.K. Advani, raising the Nandigram issue in the Lok Sabha on November 21, declared, "Nandigram is going to be the turning point in the history of the Communist Party." Nandigram has become the BJP's new political cause to champion even as its own demons of Gujarat refuse to fade away.

Then there is the Congress, or more precisely, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi. Left leaders consider him as much of a villain as Banerjee or the faceless

MISGUIDED: Mamata's shrill rhetoric is starting to hit home at Buddhadeb



CRISIS: Basu and CPI(M) boss Karat's silence is eloquent

Maoists who have allegedly "supplied assault weapons" to the residents of Nandigram. In the Lok Sabha discussion, Dasmunshi did his share of Left beating. He elaborated on how state governments ought to have taken greater care of people while pursuing the SEZ policy (in Nandigram). Marxist MPs Sitaram Yechury and Basudeb Acharia had earlier blamed Dasmunshi for convincing Home Minister Shivraj Patil against sending CRPF personnel to Nandigram when Buddhadeb had requested their deployment last month.

The Marxists also point to the involvement of Ali, who has been close to both the Congress and the Trinamool Congress, leading the CPI(M) to question his organisation's independence. Hannan Mollah, another CPI(M) MP from West Bengal, described the disturbances in Kolkata as "part of the plan by anti-Left forces to show the Left Front Government in a poor light". "I have a deep-rooted feeling that there is an attempt to destabilise the constitutionally elected Government of West Bengal and the pretext is Nandigram," said CPI(M) MP Gurudas Dasgupta.

However, not all communists are sympathetic to Buddhadeb's plight. A senior CPI(M) leader feels the chief minister was "wrong in assuming that communism is a stagnant theory".

This he said in reference to Buddhadeb's remarks (in 2006) on the need to replace dogmatic communism with pragmatic communism. But then that was when Buddhadeb had won a landslide assembly election and had dreamt of his state's economic resurgence. Buddhadeb's rush to transform and reform has pushed him against the wall today. Large sections of minority communities, farmers and academics have supported the